

Smith Lane — Season 3, Episode 4

Title: Designing from the Inside Out: Elevating Amenities & Community Experience

Length: ~34 minutes

Hosts: Monaca Onstad & Callie Friedman

Guest: Paige Byrd — Owner & Co-President, Teal & Team

Episode Description

Monaca and Callie sit down with Paige Byrd, Owner and Co-President of Teal & Team, an award-winning architectural, interior design, and procurement firm specializing in hospitality and multifamily amenities.

The conversation explores why interior design should be prioritized earlier in the development process, how thoughtful amenity design shapes community experience, and what it means to design “from the inside out.” Paige shares insights from nearly two decades in the industry, including lessons from large-scale historic renovations, brand-driven environments, and the growing importance of wellness-focused amenities.

They also dive into team culture, budgeting strategy, and the evolving expectations of modern residents, ultimately highlighting how intentional design and strong collaboration lead to better communities.

What You'll Hear in This Episode

Why Interiors Shouldn't Be an Afterthought

Interior design is often rushed late in projects, despite years spent planning exteriors.

Bringing designers in early leads to better coordination, fewer constraints, and stronger outcomes.

“It is never too early” to involve interior design in the process.

About Teal & Team

National, award-winning firm specializing in hospitality and multifamily amenities.

Team of ~30 professionals including architects, interior designers, and procurement specialists.

Based in Dallas-Fort Worth, working with clients across the country.

Focus on amenities as the “jewel box” where community comes to life.

Designing Amenities That Drive Community

Amenities are no longer optional, they are a key sales and lifestyle driver.

Spaces must be activated, not just visually appealing.

Programming and design must work together to create energy throughout the day.

Poorly planned spaces (no outlets, no sinks, etc.) limit usability and experience.

Architecture from the Inside Out

Design begins with lifestyle and user experience, not just exterior form.

Interiors should inform architecture, space planning, and long-term functionality.

Operational efficiency directly impacts user experience.

Focus on how spaces will function 5–10 years into the future.

Branding & Storytelling in Design

Authenticity is critical, users can easily recognize inauthentic spaces.

Strong examples include:

- Baylor Club (university-driven branding)

- Texas Tech & Virginia Tech stadium clubs

- Tower Club Dallas

Every detail, from materials to naming, should reinforce the brand story.

Case Study: Transformational Design

Ruby Hill Country Club wine cellar:

Converted from an unused laundry space into a premium member experience.

Demonstrates how underutilized spaces can become high-value amenities.

Long-Term Passion Projects

Baker Hotel & Spa (in progress since 2009):

Largest historic preservation project in Texas.

Highlights complexity of working with historic structures.

Balancing preservation with modern guest expectations.

The Evolution of Health & Wellness Amenities

Wellness is now the #1 amenity priority.

Moving beyond traditional gyms:

Indoor/outdoor fitness spaces

Meditation lawns

Bike storage & trail integration

Spa-style features (saunas, cold plunges, red light therapy)

Focus on creating unique, experience-driven wellness environments rather than competing with big-box gyms.

Designing for Modern Consumer Behavior

“Instagrammable moments” are now part of the design strategy.

Spaces must be:

Shareable

Memorable

Identity-driven

Amenity design is now a marketing and leasing tool.

Budget Ambassadors: Designing Within Constraints

Transparency with clients is key from the beginning.

Early budgeting aligned with schematic design prevents costly redesigns.

Prioritization framework:

What defines success for the project?

What is secondary?

What is unnecessary?

Great design is achievable within budget when expectations are aligned early.

Team Culture & Leadership Philosophy

Strong emphasis on servant leadership.

Leaders exist to support and empower their teams.

Culture built on:

Collaboration

Mentorship

Shared success

“It’s not about me — it’s about what we do collectively.”

Big Themes & Takeaways

Interior design should lead, not follow, the development process.

Amenities must be functional, programmed, and experiential.

Wellness is redefining community spaces.

Authentic branding and storytelling create stronger connections.

Culture and collaboration drive better project outcomes.

“What’s Your Smith Lane?”

Paige shares that her “Smith Lane” is her experience on a competitive cheer team:

- Learned teamwork, discipline, and leadership.
 - Importance of leveraging individual strengths for collective success.
 - These lessons now shape her leadership style and company culture.
 - Draws parallels between team performance and project completion, both require trust, collaboration, and shared pride.
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YouTube Chapter Markers

00:00:00 Introduction & Why Interiors Matter Early
00:01:30 Meet Paige Byrd & Teal & Team Overview
00:04:30 Career Journey & Firm Growth
00:06:30 Full-Service Approach & Project Collaboration
00:07:30 Baker Hotel Historic Project Deep Dive
00:10:00 Branding & Storytelling in Amenity Design
00:11:30 Cowboys Golf Club & Evolving Projects
00:13:00 Designing from the Inside Out
00:15:00 Lifestyle Planning & Community Experience
00:16:30 Activating Amenities & Programming Spaces
00:18:00 Teaching Residents How to Use Spaces
00:19:00 Fitness Centers & Wellness Trends
00:20:30 The Future of Health & Wellness Amenities
00:22:30 Personalization & Accessibility in Fitness Design
00:24:30 Budgeting & Being “Budget Ambassadors”
00:26:30 Team Culture & Leadership Philosophy
00:29:30 What is Your “Smith Lane?”
00:33:00 Final Thoughts & Closing